SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #55 · POLITICS AND GOVERNMENT

“I can't trust anyone in authority.”

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Where it often comes from

Abuse of power, broken promises, scandals, or a harsh parent or boss can teach that people in charge are dangerous or corrupt. We become suspicious, defensive, or rebellious, even toward good leaders.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture is honest about corrupt rulers, and also about good ones. Peter and the apostles said, “We must obey God rather than men.” Paul writes, “Remind the believers to submit to rulers and authorities… to malign no one, and to be peaceable and gentle,” and Proverbs warns, “The simple man believes every word, but the prudent man watches his steps.” Jesus said, “be as shrewd as snakes and as innocent as doves.” The healthy path is discernment: not blind trust and not blanket distrust. Our deepest trust belongs to God, who is always trustworthy.

> *“Behold, I am sending you out like sheep among wolves; therefore be as shrewd as snakes and as innocent as doves”* (Matthew 10:16).

Also see

> “But Peter and the other apostles replied, ‘We must obey God rather than men.’” (Acts 5:29).

> “Remind the believers to submit to rulers and authorities, to be obedient and ready for every good work, to malign no one, and to be peaceable and gentle, showing full consideration to everyone” (Titus 3:1–2).

> “The simple man believes every word, but the prudent man watches his steps” (Proverbs 14:15).

> “Everyone must submit himself to the governing authorities, for there is no authority except that which is from God. The authorities that exist have been appointed by God” (Romans 13:1).

Common self-statements

- All leaders are corrupt.
- They will use me.
- I have to protect myself from them.
- Authority means danger.
- I trust no one in charge.
- They are all the same.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing authorities are either perfect or corrupt.
- Mind reading: Assuming bad intent.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling betrayed and concluding that all are untrustworthy.
- Fortune telling: Predicting harm.

Challenging questions

- Who hurt my trust in authority, and what happened?
- Have I met any authority who was trustworthy?

- What does discernment look like instead of blanket distrust?
- What does Scripture say about authority?
- Where is my deepest trust?
- How could I test trust in small steps?

Truth summary

> Some leaders failed me, but not all authorities are dangerous. I can grow in discernment, speak up when needed, and place my deepest trust in God, who is always faithful.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Trust
- Wisdom
- Forgiveness
- Obedience
- Anger

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Death and Dying
- Pride

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

Truth Be Told — Matthew West featuring Carly Pearce
Honesty about struggles makes room for grace and support instead of pretending to be fine.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I can't trust anyone in authority"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I can't trust anyone in authority." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who hurt my trust?
- ☐ Who was trustworthy?
- ☐ What is discernment?
- ☐ What does Scripture say?
- ☐ Where is my trust?
- ☐ What small test?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I must obey God above men.
- ☐ I can be shrewd and innocent.
- ☐ The prudent watch their steps.
- ☐ Not all authorities are the same.
- ☐ I can give trust in small steps.
- ☐ God is always trustworthy.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Matthew 10:16
  "Behold, I am sending you out like sheep among wolves; therefore be as shrewd as snakes and as innocent as doves."
- ☐ Proverbs 14:15
  "The simple man believes every word, but the prudent man watches his steps."
- ☐ Acts 5:29
  "But Peter and the other apostles replied, 'We must obey God rather than men.'"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Discernment, not distrust: Each week, note one authority you assessed fairly.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Matthew 10:16 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can be shrewd and innocent, and trust God above all.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Trust" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Name the hurt. Write who hurt your trust and what happened.
- [ ] List trustworthy ones. Write any authority who earned your respect.
- [ ] Test small. Trust someone with something small.
- [ ] Pray for wisdom. Ask for discernment.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I can't trust anyone in authority": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Discernment, not distrust
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I can't trust anyone in authority.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I was hurt by those in charge. Heal my trust, give me discernment, and help me trust You above all, who never fail. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.